

Chanakya WhatsApp Bot

Cost Summary — What This Costs to Run

Prepared for: Business Owners | Chanakya – The Bag Studio

This document explains, in plain terms, what it costs each month to run the WhatsApp chatbot that handles repair bookings, order tracking, store info, and customer questions. There are two cost buckets: a small fixed hosting fee, and per-message charges from WhatsApp's parent company (Meta) that only apply in specific, limited situations. Most of what the bot does is free.

~Rs. 450–650 Estimated total / month	Rs. 0 Cost per customer conversation*
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**For the normal case: a customer messages the bot and it replies. This is the vast majority of all activity.*

The Two-Bucket Summary

Bucket	What it is	Monthly cost
1. Hosting	Keeping the bot running 24/7 on a server	~Rs. 420–630 (fixed)
2. WhatsApp messaging	Meta's per-message charges — only for specific message types	~Rs. 0–150 (usage-based, currently minimized by design)

Bucket 1 — Hosting (Fixed Monthly Cost)

The bot is a small computer program that must run continuously, 24 hours a day, so it can answer customers the moment they message — including outside business hours. This requires renting a small slice of server capacity from a cloud provider, the same way you'd pay for electricity to keep a shop sign lit.

Chosen provider: Railway. First month is free (a one-time trial credit), after which it settles to a flat **\$5/month (~Rs. 420)**. This is a predictable, fixed bill — it does not change based on how many customers message the bot.

This is on the cheaper end of reliable options; we compared several providers before choosing this one, prioritizing that a business-critical customer line should not go down.

Bucket 2 — WhatsApp Messaging (Usage-Based, Mostly Free)

WhatsApp (via Meta) has a simple rule that drives almost all of the cost logic: **if the bot is replying to something the customer just said, it's free**. Charges only apply when the business sends a message to a customer *proactively* — without them having said anything recently.

The Three Message Categories

Category	When it applies	Cost
Free reply	Customer messages the bot; bot replies within the same day. Covers: menus, repair booking, order tracking, store info, T&Cs, FAQs — essentially everything a customer experiences.	Rs. 0
Utility (proactive)	The bot needs to tell a customer something important (e.g. “your bag is ready”) but they haven’t messaged recently. Used sparingly by design — see next page.	~Rs. 0.13 / message
Marketing	Promotional broadcasts (offers, sales announcements) sent to a customer list. Not currently used — this feature exists but is switched off.	~Rs. 1.02 / message

Prices shown include 18% GST and are Meta's published India rates.

How Messaging Costs Are Kept Near Zero

The bot has been deliberately built to avoid the paid “Utility” category wherever possible, using a rule that mirrors how a helpful shop employee would behave:

The Rule the Bot Follows

- **If a customer has messaged the bot recently** (within about a day), any update about their repair — status changed, inspection done, ready soon — is sent **immediately and for free**. This covers the great majority of active customers, since people checking on a repair tend to be in touch.
- **If a customer has gone quiet for more than a day**, the bot stays silent for routine updates — they can check anytime themselves by messaging “Track My Repair,” which is always free. The bot does *not* spend money nudging someone with minor updates they haven't asked for.
- **The one exception:** when a bag becomes **ready for pickup**, that's the one update worth paying for even to a quiet customer — it's the message that actually brings them back into the store to collect and pay. This is the only scenario where the small –0.13 charge is intentionally spent.

In other words: the bot only ever spends money on the one message that has a direct return (getting a customer to come collect their bag). Everything else defaults to free.

Rough Monthly Estimate

For a shop processing on the order of 150–300 repair tickets a month, the paid “ready for pickup” messages alone would add roughly **Rs. 0–150/month** depending on how many of those customers happen to be quiet at the moment their bag is ready. Everything else — the day-to-day conversation, booking, tracking, corporate enquiries — costs nothing regardless of volume.

Built-In Safety Nets (No Surprise Bills)

- A hard daily and per-minute cap on how many messages the bot can ever send, so a technical glitch cannot run up an unexpected bill.
- A manual “off switch” that can instantly stop all outbound messages if anything looks wrong, while the bot keeps receiving customer messages normally.
- Promotional/marketing broadcasts (the most expensive category) are switched off by default and would need to be deliberately turned on.

Other Services Used (All Free at This Scale)

Service	What it's for	Cost
Google Sheets	Stores every repair ticket, customer contact, and corporate enquiry — your live database	Free
Cloudinary	Stores the “before” and “after” repair photos	Free tier (well within limits at this volume)
GitHub	Private backup / version history of the bot's code	Free

Bottom Line

Running this bot costs roughly the same as a couple of cups of chai a day — a fixed **~Rs. 420–630/month** for hosting, plus a small, usage-based amount for the one type of message worth paying for. There is no large upfront cost, no per-customer fee for ordinary conversations, and the system is designed with hard caps so it cannot run away and generate a surprise bill.

If the business later wants to run promotional broadcasts (festival offers, new stock announcements, etc.), that is a separate, opt-in decision — Meta charges roughly Rs. 1 per promotional message sent, and this would only ever happen if explicitly turned on for a specific campaign.

Figures are estimates based on Meta's published India pricing (as of 2026) and typical usage patterns for a business of this size. Actual costs may vary with message volume and Meta's pricing changes.